



with 13 players because their father or grandfather was from there...

Do you mean the PIO (Persons of Indian Origin) system? Are you not in favour of it?

No, no, I am in favour. But is it the same rule for everyone? For some teams, it's applicable, but for others, it's not. This is a problem for each country, not FIFA's. I don't like playing against Syria, for example, which has players who have never been to Syria. But the rules are what they are.

I understand that if India, with a population of 1.6 billion, accepts dual nationality, the problems would be even more. But in football, that is part of the challenge. The difference will be greater if they don't accept this. If you want to play only with Indian players, you have to build from the grassroots, especially if you want to, at least, reach the same level as other countries. But it's not

an excuse or criticism; it's the reality.

With FC Goa, you have a particular way you want to play, with players you can recruit from both India and abroad. But with the national team, the pool is limited, with different profiles of players. So how do you adapt your style?

Sometimes, at FC Goa, we play 4-2-3-1, and in another club, it might be 4-4-2 or three centre-backs, like last time with the national team. You have to adapt based on the players that you have or if the opponent is better or worse than you. Finally, the important thing is that the players understand what you're explaining more than the system itself.

In the ISL, more or less all teams can beat each other. But in the international circuit, it's easier to beat teams ranked below your national team and very difficult to beat teams ranked higher because the gap is too much. But in football,

Straight talk: 'You can never promise good results, but you can promise a lot of effort and professionalism' — Marquez on the challenges of executing his dual role. FSDL

anything can happen, and the goal is to improve. When they chose me as the national coach, I knew perfectly well that the time for training sessions would not be a lot, but I think we showed in our last game in Vietnam that even with a few days, the improvement can be substantial.

Do you have any realistic goals in mind for the national team?

[It's] Difficult [to say]. I know everyone wants India to qualify for the World Cup, but I don't think that's the right thing to talk about at the moment. That's the last part of the chain. When everyone asks me about Indian football, I tell them the ISL is the image of Indian football, but it's the last part of the chain. You need to start at the grassroots and develop the national teams. There are very, very good players at U-17 and U-20 levels. I am from Spain, where football is a religion. The team that won the European Championship had the same coach (Luis de la Fuente), who won the Euros with the U-19 (2015) and U-21 sides (2019). He then won the senior title with 70–80 per cent of the same players who came through the youth squads.

It's not something you can snap your fingers at and say we now have a good group of Indian players who will qualify [for the World Cup]. We need to work from the grassroots, going through U-15, U-17 and U-19, and then arrive at the senior team.

The reality now is we have the current national team players, but it's more important to speak about those who will arrive in the future. I am very happy with the players who are here now, and their attitude is excellent in training.

But the future of Indian football lies in the teams to come, not the current national team.

(The interview was conducted on the eve of FC Goa's ISL home game against Mumbai City FC)